The Illusion of the Given

Madhyamaka, Non-Foundational Dzogchen, and the Dissolution of the Referent

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Introduction: The Intersubjective Dilemma

When multiple observers gaze at the world and report concordant features, an instinctual metaphysical assumption is triggered: agreement must be anchored in a common, mind-independent referent standing behind appearances. If two humans observe a river, or if a human, an animal, and an insect navigate the same terrain, ordinary realism demands an underlying substrate—a physical, objective constant that each creature merely registers or filters through species-specific sensory hardware.

In classical Indo-Tibetan philosophy, this tension is crystallized in the famous analysis of the "one bowl of liquid":

- To a human, it appears as refreshing, thirst-quenching water.
- To a hungry ghost (*preta*), driven by karmic traces of deprivation, it appears as putrid pus and blood.
- To an aquatic creature, it appears as an ambient atmosphere and home.
- To a celestial being (*deva*), it appears as ambrosial nectar.
- To an awakened noble being (*ārya*), it appears as the pure radiance of Māmakī, the female Buddha of the water element.

The immediate impulse of classical realism is to interpret this variation through a dualistic or Kantian lens. One assumes that a neutral, uncarved "stuff-in-itself" (whether conceived as H_2O, bare matter, or raw physical energy) occupies the coordinate space, and that differing organisms merely apply distinct cognitive and biological filters to that pre-existing given.

Yet both orthodox Prāsaṅgika-Madhyamaka and non-foundational Dzogchen reject this assumption. When subjected to rigorous analysis, the hypothesis of an inherently established common basis (*gzhi mthun rang bzhin gyis grub pa*) collapses. Furthermore, this deconstructive stance finds a striking parallel in contemporary post-foundational physics and philosophy of science—specifically Carlo Rovelli's Relational Quantum Mechanics (RQM) and Karen Barad's Agential Realism.

Agreement does not require an ultimate substrate. Regularity does not require a foundational floor. When conditions vary, appearances shift not because observers decode a single, uncarved given differently, but because objects, observers, and channels of interaction co-emerge within dependently arisen, relational networks.

1. The Trap of the Uncarved Substratum

The claim that "different species see the same liquid differently" smuggles in an unexamined noun: *the liquid*. It presumes that prior to any perceptual encounter, an entity already stands in quiet self-possession, waiting to be evaluated.

This is the classic retreat into Kantian transcendental idealism:

- **The Postulate:** A *Ding an sich* (thing-in-itself) exists beyond cognition, while organisms merely stamp subjective categories, spatial coordinates, and sensory modalities onto it.
- **The Madhyamaka Critique:** If this underlying substrate exists prior to and independent of being perceived, what are its actual attributes? If it has specific properties (such as thirst-quenching water), it cannot explain the preta's direct, functional encounter with burning pus. If it has no properties whatsoever, an uncharacterized, property-less substrate cannot act as an efficient cause (*arthakriyā*) to trigger any sensory cognition at all.[1]

The "Wet-and-Moist" (*rlan gsher*) Counter-Argument

A thoughtful objector will immediately resist this dilemma: "Why assume the substrate must be water or pus? Why couldn't it be 'the wet-and-moist' (*rlan gsher*)—a basic physical property common to both water and pus?"

In Tibetan scholasticism, *rlan gsher* is precisely the candidate proposed when debaters attempt to identify a shared conventional locus. But this move faces a critical fork:

1. **If *rlan gsher* is claimed as an inherently existent substrate:** The argument fails. A generic, uninstantiated "wetness" is a conceptual generality (*spyi*). In concrete reality, wetness never exists in the abstract; it exists only as *this* consumable water, *this* caustic pus, or *this* ambient aquatic medium. Moreover, physical fluidity is itself a relational encounter: what registers as fluid to macro-biological organisms with cell membranes does not function as fluid to systems operating at different scales or through different forces.
2. **If *rlan gsher* is claimed as a conventional common basis (*tha snyad kyi gzhi mthun*):** It is no longer an uncarved thing-in-itself. It becomes a prime example of an acceptable **nominal basis**—a functional, provisional designation that allows human debaters to coordinate and discuss different perspectives without pretending to point to an ultimate, observer-independent floor.

As Nāgārjuna demonstrates throughout the *Mūlamadhyamakakārikā* (MMK), the target of deconstructive analysis is ***svabhāva***—intrinsic reality, self-nature, or non-dependent being. An uncarved "neutral substrate" posited beneath appearances is simply *svabhāva* wearing an agnostic disguise.

2. Intersubjectivity Without a Substrate: The Prāsaṅgika Model

If there is no inherently established referent behind appearances, why do humans consistently agree that the liquid is water? Why doesn't the conventional world dissolve into arbitrary fantasy?

In Chapter 6 of the *Madhyamakāvatāra*, Candrakīrti provides the Prāsaṅgika-Madhyamaka answer: **agreement does not prove an underlying substrate; shared conventional coherence is the very definition of conventional truth (*saṃvṛtisatya*).**

[1] While Kant never conceived the thing-in-itself as an empirical efficient cause, and while Prāsaṅgikas accept *arthakriyā* (functional efficacy) only provisionally within unanalyzed worldly convention without adopting Dharmakīrti's criterion of ultimate reality, the epistemological point holds: a substrate stripped of all relational determinations can provide neither causal purchase nor explanatory leverage.

A. Mutual Dependence (*Parasparāpekṣā*)

Candrakīrti spends substantial effort (MA 6.45–6.97) dismantling the idealist (*Cittamātra* / Mind-Only) position, which seeks to solve the problem by eliminating external matter and making an intrinsically real consciousness (*vijñāna*) the sole ground. Candrakīrti demonstrates that mind and object (*viṣaya*) stand in a relationship of strict mutual dependence:

- A perceiving consciousness cannot be established without reference to an object.
- An object cannot be established without reference to the perceptual and conceptual framework that delineates it.

Neither consciousness nor matter enjoys ontological priority. To make mind the foundational container is just as mistaken as making physical matter the container.

B. Sound Faculties vs. Impairment Within Designated Classes

Candrakīrti distinguishes operable conventionalities (*tathyasaṃvṛti*) from erroneous conventionalities (*mithyāsaṃvṛti*) using the examples of clear vision versus jaundice or ophthalmia (*timira*, MA 6.24–6.28).

Crucially, **impairment is defined strictly within a biological or karmic class:**

- The human with jaundice sees a white conch as yellow. Because other humans with sound visual faculties see it as white, the jaundiced human is conventionally mistaken by human standards.
- The preta, however, is not a "jaundiced human." Relative to the preta's own karmic conditioning, its faculties are unimpaired *by preta standards*. It is not suffering an optical illusion of water; the substance genuinely functions as pus within its operative conventionality.

Furthermore, Candrakīrti emphasizes that the split between *tathya* (correct) and *mithyā* (erroneous) holds **only from the standpoint of worldly consensus (*lokaprasiddha*)**. From the perspective of noble beings (*āryas*) resting in meditative equipoise, *all* dualistic conventional appearance is *mithyā*—untrue and deceptive—because it appears to possess an inherent existence that it utterly lacks.

C. The Gelug Concession: The Nature of the Nominal Observed Basis (*dmigs gzhi tsam*)

To avoid collapsing into nihilism (*ucchedavāda*), the Gelug tradition (following Tsongkhapa, Jamyang Shepa, and Panchen Sonam Drakpa) draws a vital distinction:

Table 1. The Gelug distinction on the common basis

What Gelug Strictly Negates	What Gelug Conventionally Accepts
An intrinsically established common basis (*gzhi mthun rang bzhin gyis grub pa*): a mind-independent physical substance possessing its own ontological identity prior to perception.	A mere nominal observed basis (*dmigs gzhi tsam* / *snang gzhi tsam*): a dependently designated convergence point where different karmic appearances meet.

What prevents this *dmigs gzhi tsam* from collapsing back into a Kantian *Ding an sich*?

The observed basis is not a bearer of properties that precedes its relations. It has no characteristics beyond those that hold relative to some channel of coupling. It is a designation made from

within a particular conventional frame, usually the human one (*tha snyad pa'i tshad ma*), which lets different perspectives be referred to one another. Its job is to coordinate, not to underlie. It does in Madhyamaka what cross-perspective coordination does in relational physics, not what a substance does in classical realism.

3. The Phenomenological Shift: Non-Foundational Dzogchen

While Prāsaṅgika-Madhyamaka uses relentless dialectics to deconstruct metaphysical claims and halt analysis at worldly convention, the Great Perfection (Dzogchen) articulates the experiential nature of appearances through a phenomenological vocabulary.

A. The Ground (*gzhi*) is Not an Ontological Substrate (*kun gzhi*)

In the non-foundational lineages of Dzogchen—illuminated by Longchenpa in his *Seven Treasuries* and clarified by Ju Mipham Rinpoche—the Ground (*gzhi*) is carefully distinguished from the *ālaya* / *kun gzhi* (the karmic substrate storehouse):

- The Ground is described through three inseparable aspects: **primordial purity** (*ka dag*, its empty essence), **spontaneous presence** (*lhun grub*, its unceasing display), and **all-pervasive responsiveness** (*thugs rje*).
- Primordial purity ensures that the Ground is thoroughly devoid of substantial reality (*svabhāva*). It is not an uncarved block, a cosmic mind, or a metaphysical origin. The Ground is "ground" only relative to the path; in itself, it is free from all ontological extremes (*mtha' bral*).

B. Self-Display (*rang snang*): Mind (*sems*) versus Awareness (*rig pa*)

Appearances are characterized as the dynamic display (*rtsal*, *rol pa*) of the ground, manifesting as **self-display** (*rang snang*).

To prevent this from sliding back toward mentalism or making consciousness the hidden source of the world, Dzogchen's own distinction between dualistic mind (*sems*) and pure awareness (*rig pa*) is essential:

- **The Subject Pole is Part of the Display:** Dualistic consciousness (*sems*)—the interior subject that grasps—is itself an appearance, arising symmetrically alongside the external object (*yul*). Neither mind nor matter is the source of the other; both are co-emergent polarities within the display.
- **Awareness is Not a Radiating Container:** Pure awareness (*rig pa*) is not one half of this subject–object pair, nor is it a subtle mental substance that projects outer forms. When Dzogchen describes appearances as the display of rig pa, it means that the entire perceptual field, subject and object together, is not other than empty, luminous cognizance (*ngo bo stong pa, rang bzhin gsal ba*). This is not a further substance underlying the field but the field's own mode of being, itself empty.
- **Display is Not Causal Production:** The Ground does not "generate" appearances as a cause produces an effect. Spontaneous presence (*lhun grub*) is not an unconditioned creative source churning out conditioned objects. Rather, appearances are unproduced, self-luminous radiance, empty from the very moment of their arising.

C. Reflexive Awareness (*rang rig*): A Deliberate Shift in Framework

This brings the synthesis to a major historical divide. In *Madhyamakāvatāra* 6.72ff, Candrakīrti rejects reflexive awareness (*svasaṃvedana* / *rang rig*), the argument Śāntideva later made famous in *Bodhicaryāvatāra* 9.17–18 (which draws on earlier sutra formulations such as the *Ratnacūḍa-sūtra*): an entity cannot act upon itself, just as a sword cannot cut its own blade. Following Candrakīrti, Tsongkhapa makes the rejection of *rang rig* even conventionally one of his Eight Difficult Points (*dka' gnad brgyad*).

Here, **the synthesis explicitly follows Ju Mipham Rinpoche rather than Tsongkhapa:**

- **Ultimately:** Mipham completely affirms the Prāsaṅgika refutation. Under ultimate analysis (*paramārtha-vicāra*), no intrinsically established awareness or reflexive knowing can be found. *Rang rig* is empty of inherent existence.
- **Conventionally:** Mipham defends *rang rig* within conventional discourse (*tha snyad*) to account for memory and immediate cognitive experience without spawning an infinite regress of secondary witness-consciousnesses.
- In Dzogchen, the self-knowing nature of *rig pa* is not an intrinsically real subject knowing itself as an intentional object; it is the natural absence of delusion (*ma rig pa*)—the immediate, unconstructed lucidity of awareness recognizing its own empty display.

D. Mipham's Fourfold Epistemology and Pure Vision (*dag gzigs*)

Mipham organizes valid cognition (*pramāṇa*) into a fourfold framework:

1. **Impure Conventional Valid Cognition (*tshur mthong tshad ma*):** Operates within samsaric karmic vision (*las snang*), bound by habitual traces (*bag chags*). **Devas belong here:** their experience of liquid as nectar is an elevated karmic vision, not awakened pure vision.
2. **Pure Conventional Valid Cognition (*dag gzigs kyi tshad ma*):** Belonging to noble beings (*āryas*), where the liquid appears with specific conventional content: **Māmakī, the female Buddha of the water element**.
3. **Categorized Ultimate Valid Cognition (*rnam grangs pa'i don dam*):** The analytical realization of emptiness arrived at through intellectual negation.
4. **Uncategorized Ultimate Valid Cognition (*rnam grangs min pa'i don dam*):** The non-conceptual, direct realization of the inseparable unity of primordial purity and spontaneous presence.

Connecting Horizontal Relativity and Vertical Ranking

How does this reconcile with Candrakīrti's horizontal conventionalism (§2B)?

Mipham holds both perspectives together: **Within impure vision (*tshur mthong*), validity is strictly relative to the class of beings.** The preta's vision of pus is unimpaired by preta standards; the human's vision of water is unimpaired by human standards. Neither has an absolute vantage over the other within the samsaric sphere. **Between impure and pure vision, however, there is a vertical ranking governed by gnas snang mthun pa**—the concordance of "how things appear" (*snang tshul*) with "how things actually are" (*gnas tshul*).

Why Pure Vision Does Not Smuggle in a Foundation: Does *gnas snang mthun pa* re-introduce an objective ground? The crucial step is recognizing that **the pure vision of the mandala is itself empty—the inseparable union of appearance and emptiness (snang stong zung 'jug).** Pure vision is appearance without the obscuration of dualistic error (*'khrul pa*) and adventitious stains (*glo bur gyi dri ma*); it is not access to a metaphysical bedrock behind appearance. In Dzogchen, spontan-

eous presence (*lhun grub*) asserts that phenomena are primordially pure and complete as the mandala of deities and wisdoms at the level of appearance. Because the deity Māmakī is completely devoid of inherent existence (*svabhāva*), pure vision is accurate not because it finds an ultimate object, but because it experiences appearance without the reifying distortion that splits reality into independent subjects and solid, external things.

4. Modern Relationalism: Rovelli, Barad, and Cross-Perspective Consistency

This dissolution of the given without falling into subjective idealism is mirrored in contemporary post-foundational physics and relational epistemology.

Karen Barad's Agential Realism

In *Meeting the Universe Halfway*, Karen Barad replaces classical *interaction* with ***intra-action***:

- **No Pre-existing Relata:** Traditional metaphysics presumes independent entities that subsequently interact. In agential realism, relata do not pre-exist their intra-action; they emerge through it.
- **The Agential Cut:** Boundaries and properties are enacted through specific material-discursive apparatuses. The cut does not slice up a pre-existing reality; it enacts what counts as the "observer" and what counts as the "observed" within a specific phenomenon.

There is no "liquid" standing prior to the cut. The human-as-drinker and the liquid-as-water co-emerge within human physiological-cultural intra-action. The preta-as-sufferer and the liquid-as-pus co-emerge within the preta karmic intra-action.

Carlo Rovelli's Relational Quantum Mechanics (RQM) and Cross-Perspective Links

In RQM, variables do not take values absolutely; they take values **only relative to another physical system during an interaction**.

The 2022 Postulate: Cross-Perspective Links: Early formulations of RQM faced a serious challenge: if all physical facts are strictly relative to individual systems, what prevents the universe from fracturing into solipsistic, isolated reality-fragments? Why do two observers agree when they compare notes? Standard quantum mechanics was argued by critics to lack a built-in guarantee of inter-observer consistency across independent relational interactions.

To resolve this, Emily Adlam and Carlo Rovelli (2022) introduced the **Cross-Perspective Links (CPL)** postulate: if system O interacts with system S and registers a value, and observer O' subsequently interacts with both O and S to verify the result, the measurement outcome registered by O' will be found in coherent alignment with the record of O.

Some critics argue that CPL seems to concede a shared structure of stable facts across perspectives. This is less a concession than a confirmation of the relational thesis: agreement between two observers does *not* require an unmeasured, classical state to have existed prior to interaction. Rather, agreement is established via physical interaction channels between the observers themselves. Intersubjective coherence is produced through horizontal relational coordination and cross-checking—a close counterpart of Candrakīrti's corroboration among sound faculties (§2B)—not by anchoring to an absolute classical substrate.

5. Differential Coupling and Relational Affordances

If an appearance requires a specific configuration of faculties, conditions, and interaction channels, what occurs when a class of beings encounters an environmental region with which it shares **little or no coupling**?

The answer is neither an "absolute ontological zero" (which lapses into subjective solipsism and erases conventional reality) nor an uncarved classical object (which lapses into foundationalism). Rather, **relational coupling comes in degrees, and the facts that hold relative to a system track precisely which physical and cognitive channels are coupled.**

A. Uexküll's *Umwelt* and Causal Blind Spots

In biosemiotics, Jakob von Uexküll demonstrated that an organism does not experience a generic environment, but rather an ***Umwelt***—a functional world carved out by its sensory-effector loops:

- The common tick responds primarily to three signals: butyric acid, 37°C temperature, and hairiness.
- A pool of clear spring water lacks these semiotic triggers. To the tick, the water does not appear as an affordance; it does not exist within the tick's perceptual map.

However, the water is not an "ontological zero" for the tick: **the tick can still drown in the water**. The tick is uncoupled from the optical and semiotic channels of the water, but it remains coupled to its fluid dynamics and surface tension. This demonstrates why conventional reality is not relativized to a private mind: causal impact (*arthakriyā*) operates along specific relational channels regardless of whether an organism has conceptual or perceptual awareness of it.

B. Differential Coupling in Physics

Physical systems reveal this same tiered relationality:

- **The Gravitational Channel:** Consider dark matter passing through the Earth. As far as current empirical observations show, dark matter does not couple to the electromagnetic force, so it passes through the ~12,700 kilometers of the Earth's dense crust and mantle without friction, collision, or mechanical resistance. To an electromagnetic sensor, the Earth is an impenetrable barrier; to dark matter, that barrier does not exist. Yet dark matter *is* coupled through the gravitational channel: its trajectory is bent by the Earth's mass-energy.
- **The Neutrino:** A solar neutrino passes through vast expanses of lead with an extraordinarily low probability of interaction. The lead is neither an impenetrable wall nor non-existent; it is a region of extremely weak relational coupling.

C. Classical Parallels: Non-Obstruction and the Absence of Affordances

This continuum of coupling resolves the classical Buddhist accounts without demanding an uncarved substrate:

- **Subtle spirits passing through mountains:** Spirits whose karmic bodies share no coarse elemental density pass unobstructed through rock faces. Solidity is not an intrinsic property of the stone; it is a relational resistance actualized only when two systems of similar physical density collide.

- **The Formless Realm (*Ārūpyadhātu*):** Beings in formless meditative states have deactivated coarse sensory aggregations; physical affordances are completely inoperative relative to their cognitive frame.

The bowl of liquid remains a **nominal observed basis (*dmigs gzhi tsam*)**. It is not erased from conventional existence merely because an uncoupled observer fails to register it. But what that basis manifests as—whether an impenetrable barrier, fluid nourishment, burning pus, or an uncoupled passage—depends entirely on the relational channels enacted in the encounter, with the human frame coordinating the terms of comparison.

6. The Dissolution of the Container Myth

Why does realism so persistently cling to an underlying object? The root obstacle is the **Container Myth** (the Cartesian and Newtonian intuition of absolute space and time):

1. We imagine space as an empty, pre-existing three-dimensional container.
2. We place a solid object in the center of the room.
3. We place observers inside the container and assume they must either interact with the pre-existing object or suffer an illusion.

Modern physics and Madhyamaka dismantle this container:

- **General Relativity and Quantum Gravity:** In Einstein's physics, spacetime is not an empty stage; **spacetime is the gravitational field itself**—a dynamic physical entity that interacts with matter and energy. In loop quantum gravity, spin networks describe quantized states of the gravitational field itself; space has discrete quanta and emerges relationally.
- **Madhyamaka Deconstruction:** In MMK Chapter 5 (*Analysis of the Elements / Dhātuparīkṣā*), Nāgārjuna demonstrates that space (*ākāśa*) cannot exist prior to its defining characteristics (such as non-obstruction). Space and the entities within it are co-dependent designations.

When space ceases to be an absolute warehouse, the puzzle of how an object can appear differently across species dissolves. Space, time, observer, and observed are all mutually dependent threads within a single, dynamic web of conditions.

7. The Question of Regularity: Why Is There a Coherent Web?

This brings the inquiry to the fundamental question that realism poses against relational ontology: "If there is no ultimate, objective ground, why is there an orderly, reliable web of conditions at all? Why do conditions cohere into predictable laws, regularities, and repeatable experiences rather than collapsing into chaotic noise?"

Foundationalist thought presumes this question requires an ultimate metaphysical ground—a prime mover, an absolute law, or a fundamental material substratum. Madhyamaka and non-foundational Dzogchen address this through two distinct, complementary moves:

A. The Conventional Answer: Dependent Regularity (*Idaṃpratyayatā*)

Conventionally, Madhyamaka does not leave regularity unexplained. Regularity is accounted for by the lawful nature of dependent origination (*pratītyasamutpāda*):

- Causes produce concordant effects: barley seeds produce barley, not rice; fire burns and does not freeze.
- In the realm of sentient experience, collective karma (*sādhāraṇa-karma*) and shared evolutionary conditioning constrain how appearances unfold.
- Convention has its own robust, operational validity (*tathya-saṃvṛti*). To say a convention is empty of inherent existence does not mean it is arbitrary or lawless. Emptiness is not the negation of cause and effect; **emptiness is the very condition that allows cause and effect to function.**

B. The Dialectical Deconstruction: Rejecting the Premise

When pressed further—"Yes, but why is there a web as a whole?"—the question makes a subtle category error by treating the entire web of dependent arising as if it were a single, bounded entity requiring an external cause.

1. **"The Web as a Whole" is a Nominal Designation:** A totality or "system as a whole" does not exist as an independent entity standing alongside its parts. It is a conceptual imputation (*prajñapti*). To demand an external ground for the "whole" is to seek a foundation outside of all relations.
2. **Infinite Regress vs. Groundlessness:** If you posit an ultimate foundation X to explain the web, X must either be conditioned (requiring its own prior cause, continuing the chain) or unconditioned (which, lacking relations, cannot causally interact with or generate conditioned appearances). In MMK Chapter 11 (*Analysis of Prior and Posterior Extremes*), Nāgārjuna shows that dependent arising is beginningless (*anādikāla*). An infinite series of conditions is an ontological failure only if one is seeking a foundational resting place. In a relational ontology, the absence of a first beginning is simply the natural signature of groundlessness.

The question does not uncover a hidden substrate; **the question exhausts its own conceptual momentum.**

Conclusion: Groundless Functionality

To recognize that similar beings see a similar world because they share similar conditions—and not because of a mind-independent given—is not a descent into nihilism or solipsism.

- It does not collapse into **idealism**, because the mind is just as empty, conditioned, and dependently arisen as the objects it encounters.
- It does not collapse into **subjective relativism**, because conventional truth operates with lawful, intersubjectively verifiable regularity (*arthakriyā*) across shared channels of coupling.

What is eliminated is solely the metaphysical anxiety that demands a foundation—the insistence that beneath the vibrant display of appearances, there must be a dead, unmoving, objective ballast keeping everything upright.

In the Prāsaṅgika dialectic, this groundlessness is the supreme affirmation of conventional efficacy:

> *sarvaṃ ca yujyate tasya śūnyatā yasya yujyate*
>
> "For whom emptiness is possible, everything is possible."
>
> — *Mūlamadhyamakakārikā* 24.14

And from the experiential perspective of non-foundational Dzogchen, when appearances are recognized as self-display (*rang snang*), free from the dualistic friction of an inherent subject grasping at an inherent object, the display of appearances is experienced in its primordially pure nature: unoriginated, unconstructed, and vividly present. Conventional reality does not endure *in spite* of having no foundation; it is precisely because reality is free from any foundation that it is capable of appearing at all.